

Universal Design for Learning (3.0) & MTSS — Framework Alignment

Foundations of Constitutional Government · United States Government & Civics (GC) · District adoption defensibility

*The barrier is in the design of the environment, not the learner. Accommodations are designed in by default, not retrofitted. Firm goals (TN GC standards + SSPs), flexible means. This document maps the course's design decisions to the **CAST UDL Guidelines version 3.0** (all nine guidelines, thirty considerations) and to a three-tier **MTSS** model. UDL and MTSS are built in as frameworks — largely invisible on the page to teacher and student, but explicit and reviewable here. **Firm goals, flexible means:** the means vary; the TN GC standard and Social Studies Practices never do.*

Sources of truth. Framework map: 05_STANDARDS_ALIGNMENT/udl_mtss_alignment.json (machine-readable). UDL: CAST (2024). Universal Design for Learning Guidelines version 3.0. Lynnfield, MA: Author. <https://udlguidelines.cast.org/> MTSS: Tier 1 universal core (all students) · Tier 2 targeted supports · Tier 3 intensive supports, driven by progress-monitoring data.

Principle 1 — Engagement (the WHY of learning)

Multiple Means of Engagement — the WHY of learning (affective networks).

Guideline	Consideration	Status	Evidence in the course build
7. Welcoming Interests Identities	7.1 Choice And Autonomy	Designed in	- Response choice on every task: write / say (record) / draw / build. "Which Organizer, When" quick guide lets students/teachers choose the thinking tool. - Assessment response-choice: full form (A–D) or support form (A–B) as an access format, same standard.
	7.2 Relevance Value Authenticity	Designed in	- Tennessee Connection on every unit ties national civics to students' own state/community. - Verbatim primary sources and real political cartoons, not invented text. - Provocative real-world hooks open every standard.
	7.3 Joy And Play	Designed in	- Every unit carries an on-standard warm-up game on the 'Make It Stick' slide (Unit 1 'Federalism Face-Off'; Unit 2 'Nominate!'). - Curiosity-driven hooks and 'spot the bias / your verdict' challenges. - Held forward by the design contract for Units 3–7.
	7.4 Address Biases Threats Distractions	Designed in	- Neutral-framing guardrail: no loaded language; 'Who benefited / Who bore the cost' instead of winners/losers. - Judgment is left to the student's response line, never pre-decided in the design.
8. Sustaining Effort Persistence	8.1 Clarify Meaning And Purpose Of Goals	Designed in	- Verbatim 'I can' learning target on every standard. - Explicit success criteria (3-part) and cues per standard.
	8.2 Optimize Challenge And Support	Designed in	- Scaffold + Extend columns on every organizer (Tier 2 support and enrichment on the same page). - DOK range 1–4 per standard; 'choose your challenge' CER levels at one firm standard.
	8.3 Collaboration Interdependence	Designed in	Partner-first and 'talk-first' scaffolds; discuss options; card-sort collaborative moves in scaffolds.
	8.4 Foster Belonging And Community	Designed in	'Whose Voice Counted / Whose Participation Counts' multiple-perspectives sections surface historically excluded voices. - Bilingual EN/ES presence signals belonging for multilingual learners.
	8.5 Action Oriented Feedback	Designed in	- Check-for-Understanding with answer rationale (the 'why'), not just a key. - Progress self-check ('how sure are you?'); teacher-side reteach; mastery analytics feed next steps.

Guideline	Consideration	Status	Evidence in the course build
9. Emotional Capacity	9.1 Recognize Expectations Beliefs Motivations	Designed in	- A predict-first belief-check opens every unit ('Make It Stick' slide + content data), surfacing prior beliefs before instruction. - Contract-enforced for Units 3–7.
	9.2 Awareness Of Self And Others	Designed in	- Multiple-perspectives framing builds awareness of others' viewpoints (SSP.03). - Historical-empathy prompts (SSP.05) ask students to view events as people of the time.
	9.3 Individual And Collective Reflection	Designed in	CER and 'your verdict, because...' reflection lines; progress checks; unit essential-question revisit slide.
	9.4 Empathy And Restorative Practices	Designed in	- Per-unit discussion norms (Unit 1 'Constitutional Conversations'; Unit 2 'Civic Conversations') set restorative, evidence-first dialogue rules. - Perspective-taking and 'who was excluded' framing build empathy.

Principle 2 — Representation (the WHAT of learning)

Multiple Means of Representation — the WHAT of learning (recognition networks).

Guideline	Consideration	Status	Evidence in the course build
1. Perception	1.1 Customize Display Of Information	Designed in	Print-first and digital; ≥9pt type, B&W-safe, WCAG-AA contrast; web edition scales/reflows.
	1.2 Multiple Ways To Perceive Information	Designed in	Read-aloud-friendly text; primary sources presented as image + text; alt text on every image (bilingual).
	1.3 Diversity Of Perspectives And Identities	Designed in	Federalist and Anti-Federalist; enslaved & free Black Americans; women & the unenfranchised; the expanding franchise — named explicitly, not as a single 'neutral' narrative.

Guideline	Consideration	Status	Evidence in the course build
2. Language And Symbols	2.1 Clarify Vocabulary Symbols Structures	Designed in	Frayer vocabulary; per-term definitions in plain language; key-term cues in organizers.
	2.2 Support Decoding	Designed in	Phonetic pronunciation on every vocabulary term; sentence frames; word banks.
	2.3 Understanding Respect Across Languages	Designed in	Bilingual EN/ES vocabulary and alt text on every term and image — designed in, not retrofitted.
	2.4 Address Biases In Language And Symbols	Designed in	Neutral-framing substitutions enforced in titles, band labels, prompts, and criteria (guardrail).
	2.5 Illustrate Through Multiple Media	Designed in	Text + verbatim source + image/cartoon + graphic organizer + slide deck for the same idea.
3. Building Knowledge	3.1 Connect Prior Knowledge	Designed in	K-W-L reproducible; hooks activate prior knowledge; 'predict first' prompts.
	3.2 Highlight Patterns Big Ideas Relationships	Designed in	Essential question per unit; concept webs and comparison matrices; cause-effect chains.
	3.3 Cultivate Multiple Ways Of Knowing	Designed in	Primary vs. secondary source work; multiple perspectives; disciplinary practices (SSP.01–06).
	3.4 Maximize Transfer And Generalization	Designed in	- Cross-unit spiral links embedded per unit ('Spiral — retrieve & connect'): e.g., GC.08 Bill of Rights → Unit 6 cases; GC.34 petition → Unit 1 First Amendment. - CER and unit DBQ require transfer; contract-enforced forward.

Principle 3 — Action & Expression (the HOW of learning)

Multiple Means of Action & Expression — the HOW of learning (strategic networks).

Guideline	Consideration	Status	Evidence in the course build
4. Interaction	4.1 Vary Methods For Response Navigation	Designed in	Write / say / draw / build response on every task; movement via card-sorts and gallery moves in scaffolds.
	4.2 Access To Assistive And Accessible Tech	Designed in	- Digital format is screen-reader compatible; images carry alt text; print is high-contrast/B&W-safe. - Web edition designed for keyboard and AT access.

Guideline	Consideration	Status	Evidence in the course build
5. Expression And Communication	5.1 Use Multiple Media For Communication	Designed in	Students may express mastery in writing, speech (recorded), drawing, or a built product.
	5.2 Tools For Construction And Creativity	Designed in	The full graphic-organizer toolkit; CER frames; DBQ; concept webs as construction tools.
	5.3 Graduated Support For Practice And Performance	Designed in	Sentence starters and word banks → partner practice → independent performance; support-form items.
	5.4 Address Biases In Modes Of Expression	Designed in	Response choice removes the single-mode penalty; reduced-choice (A–B) is labeled an access format at the same standard, not a lower expectation.
6. Strategy Development	6.1 Set Meaningful Goals	Designed in	‘I can’ targets + success criteria make the goal explicit and student-facing.
	6.2 Anticipate And Plan For Challenges	Designed in	Scaffold column anticipates common barriers; ‘Which Organizer, When’ plans tool choice for a task.
	6.3 Organize Information And Resources	Designed in	The graphic-organizer toolkit is a dedicated Strategy-Development instrument (Venn, matrix, CER, HIPPO, timeline, concept web, etc.).
	6.4 Enhance Capacity For Monitoring Progress	Designed in	Check-for-Understanding + progress self-check + mastery analytics (standard mastery, DOK weighting, remediation triggers).
	6.5 Challenge Exclusionary Practices	Designed in	Reduced-choice as access (never a lowered ceiling); bilingual by default; multiple perspectives; neutral framing — all designed to widen access, not track students down.

MTSS — Multi-Tiered System of Supports

Supports are designed into the core materials, tiered by need, and driven by progress-monitoring data.

Tier	Role	Evidence in the course build
Tier 1 Universal	The platinum core instruction itself is Tier 1: UDL-embedded, all students, firm TN GC standard + SSP goals.	- Every lesson is print + digital, bilingual, neutral-framed, with response choice and success criteria. - Primary-source-based inquiry with graphic-organizer support for all learners.

Tier	Role	Evidence in the course build
Tier 2 Targeted	Same standard, added support for learners who need it — designed into the page, not a separate worksheet.	- Scaffold column: sentence frames, word banks, partner-first, card-sorts. - Support-form (A–B) assessment items keep the correct answer + one strong distractor. - Frayer vocabulary and pronunciation guides for language demand.
Tier 3 Intensive	Most-scaffolded pathway and teacher-directed reteach for learners needing intensive support.	- Teacher-side reteach / priority-teaching guidance in the Teacher Guide. - Most-supported response mode (say/draw/build) available at the same standard. 1:1 conferring prompts and re-teach triggers surfaced by the mastery model.
Progress Monitoring	The data layer that drives MTSS tier decisions.	- Per-standard Check-for-Understanding with DOK tags. - Mastery analytics: standard-level mastery, DOK 3–4 weighting, remediation triggers, spiral interleaving. - Formative question banks with psychometric metadata for pre-field-test analysis.

Design Contract (held on every future unit)

- Every activity offers a firm goal (the TN GC standard + SSP) and at least two flexible means to reach it.
- Every writable task offers response choice (write / say / draw / build).
- Every vocabulary term carries a plain-language definition, pronunciation, and an EN/ES gloss.
- Every image carries bilingual alt text; every page is print + digital, B&W-safe, WCAG-AA.
- Every page carries a Scaffold (Tier 2) and an Extend option without lowering the standard’s ceiling.
- Framing is neutral in titles, labels, prompts, and criteria; judgment is left to the student.
- Multiple perspectives and historically excluded voices are named, not flattened into one ‘neutral’ narrative.
- Reduced-choice and language supports are access formats at the same standard — never IEP modification labeled as UDL.

Adoption Defensibility

Population	How the design meets it
IEP	Accommodations (extended response modes, read-aloud, reduced-choice access format, graphic-organizer support) are designed into the core materials by default, satisfying least-restrictive-environment expectations without a separate retrofit.
504	Access features (high-contrast print, digital reflow, AT-compatible digital, pronunciation and language supports) are universal, not conditional on a plan.

Population	How the design meets it
WIDA	Bilingual EN/ES vocabulary and alt text, sentence frames, word banks, and multimodal representation support multilingual learners across WIDA levels while holding the same content standard.
GT	Extend options, DOK 3–4 tasks, honors prompts, and open inquiry raise the ceiling for gifted/talented learners within the same lesson.

The UDL / modification boundary: UDL never lowers the ceiling on a TN GC standard or drops an SSP. Anything that would change the skill assessed is IEP modification and is routed separately, not labeled UDL.

Internal framework-alignment document for district curriculum review. Not a claim of state, waiver, or Textbook Commission approval. UDL Guidelines © CAST, used as an alignment reference.